THE SOOKRA METHODOLOGY

v 3 . 3

A Competition Framework for Building, Pitching, and Winning

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May 2026 · Private Working Document

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01 WHAT IS NEW

What's New in v3.3

v3.3 is the methodology's biggest jump since v3.0. The upgrade was forged through a six-model deep research pipeline (ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Grok, Kimi, DeepSeek) plus a Claude synthesis layer, validated against published academic literature through NotebookLM, then stress-tested through /sookra-council before shipping.

Five new sections

- **Section 02 — Competition Fit Filter.** A 0–3 score across six checks decides whether the event is a winning room or a learning room before any concept work begins.
- **Section 05 — 72-Hour Pre-Game Positioning Protocol.** A locked countdown (T-72 / T-48 / T-24) that converts cold concept generation into pre-filtered, sponsor-sharp, demo-ready execution.
- **Section 11 — Rubric Reconnaissance Protocol.** Runs parallel to Sponsor Reconnaissance on Day 0. Maps the event's published scoring rubric to a Universal Translation Table so the build optimizes for how judges will actually score.
- **Section 12 — Pre-Mortem Protocol.** A 20–30 minute structured exercise at the start of the build phase. Team imagines the project has already failed and reasons backward to surface private doubts the Council's structured probing won't catch.
- **Section 19 — Post-Event AAR Protocol.** A four-probe debrief within 48 hours of every event, win or lose. Captures the empirically-validated 20–25% performance lift (Tannenbaum & Cerasoli 2013; Keiser & Arthur 2021) and is designed to move concepts out of the 93% hackathon graveyard.

Three expanded sections

- **Pillar 2 — Four-Test Falsification Battery.** Replaces the old 'spreadsheet plus phone call' intuition pump with a structured four-test protocol that catches coordination gaps and funding gaps dressed as structural gaps. Includes a sharpened six-category structural-barrier taxonomy.
- **Section 09 (Pitch Arc) — Judge Frame Routing.** Adds a real-time question-tagging protocol and judge-lens classification system. Includes spillover caveat for events with explicit judge prompting.
- **Section 06 (Section 9 Output Format) — Validator Receipt + Calibration Prediction.** Two new required fields. The Validator Receipt

names the human proof. The Calibration Prediction logs the team's placement forecast for Brier-score tracking across events.

Two updated sections

- **Rule #5 — Pitch-order rehearsal addendum.** Pitching first or second reduces average judge interest by 0.36 standard deviations (Clingingsmith, Conley & Shane). At least five of the twenty rehearsals must be optimized for the early-slot opening.
- **Section 13 (The Council) — Convergence Type field.** The Chairman's Verdict now records whether the verdict was Unanimous-Conventional, Unanimous-Unique, Split-Conventional, or Split-Unique. Split-Unique is where the biggest wins likely hide (Gius).

One new Golden Rule

- **Rule #13 — Run a Murder Board Before You Pitch.** Sunday morning, after the twenty solo rehearsals and after the backup video is recorded. Three Kill Shots: weakest pillar, demo contingency, differentiation. Cap at two cycles to avoid robotic delivery.

Retroactive cleanup

- **Pillar 5 Phase 2 probes renamed.** The Bezos-frame probe is now the Flywheel Probe. The Hormozi-frame probe is now the Offer-Leak Probe. The methodology absorbs frames, not founder names — v3.3 closes the four naming-discipline leaks that had crept in across versions.

One placeholder for v3.4

- **Section 20 — Reserved for v3.4: Double-Loop Methodology Audit.** Held until Section 19 has produced AAR data from three or more events. Shipping meta-process on top of un-validated process violates the methodology's own evidence discipline.

"*Convergence this clean across six frontier models plus NotebookLM validation plus Council cross-corrected fixes is genuinely rare. v3.3 is the strongest version of the methodology by a substantial margin — but only because the validation pass was allowed to do its job.*"

02 FIT FILTER

Competition Fit Filter

Before Round 1, score the room before you score the idea. This is the gate. If the event's rubric does not reward what the methodology builds, you can still enter for learning, networking, or sponsor access — but do not confuse a learning room with a winning room.

What to pull

- The official rubric (Devpost criteria, pitch competition PDF, sponsor track requirements)
- Prize categories and weights
- Judge bios — names, companies, prior wins
- Sponsor track details — required APIs, sponsor priorities
- Submission format — Devpost project page, video pitch, live demo
- Judging style — rubric-scored, pairwise comparison (Gavel), or unstructured

The Six-Check Sookra Fit Score

Score 0, 1, 2, or 3 on each check based on how explicit the rubric language is. Maximum total: 18.

1. **Human problem rewarded.** Does the rubric explicitly reward solving a real human problem with a named user? ("Real-World Application," "Social Impact," "User Need")
2. **Structural gap rewarded.** Does the rubric reward novel structural insight? ("Innovation," "Originality," "WOW Factor")
3. **Working demo rewarded.** Does the rubric reward live working software? ("Technical Execution," "Completion," "Functionality")
4. **Business numbers rewarded.** Does the rubric reward TAM, revenue model, market potential? ("Business Model," "Market Potential," "Impact")
5. **Required tech / sponsor APIs naturally usable.** Does the methodology's stack align with what sponsors expect to see integrated?
6. **Judge experience level.** Are the judges experienced VCs / industry experts / faculty (high score) or peer student judges (low score)? Experienced judges weight structural gap and business numbers; inexperienced judges weight visual command and clear 'why' framing.

Decision rule

- **Three or more checks score 2+ → HIGH FIT.** Enter to win. Apply the full methodology.

- **One to two checks score 2+ → MEDIUM FIT.** Enter selectively. Adjust emphasis per Section 11 (Rubric Reconnaissance).
- **Zero checks score 2+ → LOW FIT.** Enter only for learning, networking, or sponsor relationship-building. Do not expect to place.

"*Section 10 tells you what the sponsor wants built. Section 11 tells you how the judges will score it. Section 02 tells you whether the room is worth entering.*"

03 PILLARS

The Five Pillars

Every concept passes through five gates before code is written. If any pillar collapses, REFRAME. The methodology's track record is built on this filter.

PILLAR 1 — Real Problem, Named Person

Not a demographic. A specific person, named in the pitch, with a concrete situation. "Maria, a 64-year-old diabetic mother whose daughter drives ninety minutes for a podiatrist check" — not "diabetic patients." The named person makes the problem feel inevitable; abstractions feel optional.

PILLAR 2 — Structural Gap (Falsifiable in v3.3)

The problem has a structural barrier that prevents current solutions from working. Not coordination ("just call them"), not funding ("just pay someone"), not awareness ("just tell them"). Your gap must survive all four tests. Run them in order. If any test fails, the gap is NOT structural — REFRAME before Council.

TEST 1 — The Counterfactual Organization (90 seconds)

Name one existing organization that knows this problem exists. Why haven't they solved it? If "they don't care" → you failed Pillar 1 (your named person is wrong). If "they haven't gotten around to it" → that's coordination, not structural. If "they have, and the market is saturated" → that's a competitive gap, not structural.

TEST 2 — The Job-Lock Test (2–3 minutes)

Write: "When [circumstance], [named person] wants to [functional job] so they can [outcome]." Then list what they're hiring today — including non-technical solutions (a phone call, a spreadsheet, a sticky note, doing nothing). If the current hire is a spreadsheet plus phone call and it works well enough, the gap is coordination, not structural. If the job is one-time or highly infrequent, reconsider whether a hackathon is the right format.

TEST 3 — The Relative Incentive Test (90 seconds)

Name one organization with BOTH (a) the capital to solve this problem and (b) clear incentive to solve it. Has this organization solved it? If yes → not a structural gap. If no → name the specific structural barrier preventing them. The barrier must be one of six categories below.

The Six-Category Structural-Barrier Taxonomy

Category	Definition	Example
Statutory / Regulatory	Laws prevent the obvious solution.	Trace — federal data-sharing restrictions between NAMUS and NCIC.
Schema / Ontological	Existing data exists but can't interoperate.	Trace — forensic vocabulary ("avian motif demographic") vs layperson vocabulary ("eagle tattoo").
Liability / Clinical-Validation	Technical solution exists but trust / approval barriers block deployment.	StepSafe — FDA clearance + insurance liability block consumer DFU detection from incumbent medical-device companies.
Training-Data Missing	Model can't be built because labeled data doesn't exist at scale.	Specialized clinical or domain-specific corpora where no public dataset exists.
Perverse-Incentive Structure (sharpened v3.3)	Parties with capability are structurally optimized for a different paying customer or outcome AND no entrant can capture the underserved customer profitably without subsidy.	SafeHaven — banks profit from joint accounts; no entrant can profitably build domestic-abuse detection at consumer scale without B2G or insurance subsidy.
Coordination-Without-Authority	No single party has both information and decision authority to act.	PyroLens — NOAA has weather data, state forestry has land authority, NASA FIRMS has fire data; no integration mandate at the operational layer.

Important: the sharpened perverse-incentive category requires BOTH conditions. "The bank doesn't care about this segment" alone is a coordination or funding gap and FAILS Test 3.

TEST 4 — The Systematic Repeatability Test (2 minutes)

Generate three distinct scenarios where the same structural obstacle recurs. Different domains okay; the obstacle type must be the same. If you cannot generate

three scenarios in two minutes, the gap is too narrow — you have a feature, not a product.

PILLAR 3 — Human-Scale Statistic

One statistic. Sourced to a primary publication (peer-reviewed paper, government report, journalism with primary sourcing — never Wikipedia, never "according to"). Specific enough to feel personal. "1 in 3 foster youth experience housing instability within 2 years of aging out" (HHS) — not "foster youth face challenges."

PILLAR 4 — Tech as Inevitable Answer

The technology is not the coolest answer — it is the only logical answer. The demo moment must produce a "shouldn't be possible" reaction. If a judge could imagine the problem solved without your specific technical approach, Pillar 4 is weak.

PILLAR 5 — Business Numbers (Two-Phase)

Phase 1 — Foundational Probes. Three questions every concept must answer: (1) What is the TAM? (Real number, sourced.) (2) What is the cost per incident? (What does the problem cost society or the affected party?) (3) What is the revenue model? (Who pays, how much, why now.)

Phase 2 — The Flywheel Probe and the Offer-Leak Probe.

- **The Flywheel Probe (renamed v3.3, formerly Bezos-frame).** What gets better as more people use this? Name the compounding mechanism. If nothing compounds, the business is a service, not a platform.
- **The Offer-Leak Probe (renamed v3.3, formerly Hormozi-frame).** Where does the funnel leak? Trace the path from first-touch to revenue. Name the single biggest leak. If you can't, you don't understand your own funnel.

> "*A statistic proves the problem exists. A validator proves your version of the problem is real. Both are required.*"

04 TEAM

Team Composition

Three named roles. One person can carry two roles in a pinch, but all three responsibilities must be explicitly owned before the event starts.

THE PRODUCT MANAGER

Owns the Section 9 doc. Owns sponsor walks. Owns rubric reconnaissance. Runs /sookra-council sessions. Facilitates pre-mortem and post-event AAR. The PM does not write code; the PM makes sure the code being written serves the pitch.

THE BUILDER

Owns the technical build. Owns Pillar 4 inevitability — the "shouldn't be possible" demo moment lives or dies on the Builder's choices. Owns Rule #11 (demo supremacy) and Rule #12 (backup video). One Builder is the minimum; two Builders is ideal for any project requiring both frontend and ML/backend.

THE PRESENTER

Owns the pitch. Owns the twenty solo rehearsals (Rule #5). Owns the Murder Board (Rule #13). Delivers the live demo even if the Builder is the technical expert — judges read confidence from the presenter, not the code.

Working Agreements

- All three roles named and confirmed before T-72.
- One 45-minute chemistry call at T-48 — past hackathon experiences, pressure styles, mock 5-minute decision exercise.
- Document one-person / two-role coverage in case of illness or emergency.
- Agree on the kill-decision authority — usually the PM, sometimes the Presenter — for mid-build pivots.

05 PRE-GAME

72-Hour Pre-Game Positioning Protocol

Seventy-two hours before event start, the Product Manager owns a locked countdown that turns cold concept generation into pre-filtered, sponsor-sharp, demo-ready execution. **Person and problem still lock first — everything else sharpens fit.**

T-72 (Seventy-Two Hours Out)

- Pull and dissect the last 2–3 years of this exact hackathon's Devpost winners. Note: leading Pillar, demo moment that made judges lean forward, sponsor APIs used, human-scale stat that landed. Produce a one-page intel brief.
- If judges or sponsors are published in advance, map each judge's background, past wins, company priorities. Note which APIs or themes scored highest.
- Run lightweight Round 1 on 2–3 pre-filtered concepts that already pass all five Pillars and align with historical winner patterns. Archive sources.

T-48 (Forty-Eight Hours Out)

- Lock the three named roles with complementary skills and run one 45-minute chemistry call. Confirm one-person / two-role coverage and document working agreements.
- PM plus Builder(s) set up Git monorepo, API keys, deployment targets (Vercel / Hugging Face / Supabase / etc.), and any reusable boilerplate. Pre-sketch the "shouldn't be possible" demo moment architecture.
- Scan one recent domain survey paper or Twitter thread from researchers in the problem space. Discard any concept that could be solved by spreadsheet plus phone call (per Pillar 2 falsification battery).

T-24 (Twenty-Four Hours Out)

- Presenter drafts the 60-second Hook plus named-person Before / After skeleton using Section 09 Pitch Arc. Records a 30-second rough Loom of the intended demo moment (placeholder OK).
- Run the full team through one dry-run of Section 06 concept card plus weakest-Pillar stress test.
- Pack hardware (if track-relevant), backup battery, and printed one-page sponsor intel brief.

Output

One shared Notion or Google Doc containing the intel brief, team working agreements, pre-scaffolded repo link, and draft Section 9 card. This brief becomes the first input to /sookra-council at event start. Person and problem remain sacred; intel only decides which APIs and framing win.

Three Myths v3.3 Buries

- **"Random on-site team formation is fine."** Documented winners overwhelmingly pre-form high-trust, skill-balanced teams via Slack / Discord. Random teams lose the chemistry and scaffolding edge.
- **"The best ideas come from on-site brainstorming."** Winners pre-validate problems and sketch demos days or weeks ahead using Devpost analysis and recent papers. Cold ideation correlates with saturated or non-structural-gap concepts.
- **"Judge and sponsor research is overkill."** When panels are public, top teams explicitly map backgrounds and priorities. Non-research teams miss the signal that separates podium from participation.

06 OUTPUT FORMAT

Section 9 Output Format

The universal concept card. Every Sookra Council session, every pitch rehearsal, every post-event AAR returns to this artifact. Lock it before code commits.

■ PROBLEM STATEMENT

One sentence. Named person. Specific situation. The problem must feel inevitable to anyone who reads it.

■ THE GAP

Structural barrier in plain language. Run the Pillar 2 four-test falsification battery. Name the specific category from the six-category taxonomy.

■ KEY STATISTICS

One stat from a primary source. Format: "[Number] [unit] [population]. [Citation]."

■ PROPOSED APPROACH

Tech stack plus the "shouldn't be possible" demo moment. One paragraph. The Pillar 4 inevitability proof.

■ EXPECTED DELIVERABLE

What ships at submission. Working features, not aspirations.

■ BEFORE / AFTER

Two paragraphs. Named person's life before your solution exists; named person's life after. See Section 07.

■ VALIDATOR RECEIPT (NEW v3.3)

Name the human proof. Who did you talk to, observe, or validate with? User, domain expert, operator, sponsor-as-buyer, or institutional partner. Record: name plus role; date of conversation; one quote or paraphrased pain point; one contradiction they gave you; one change you made because of it.

A statistic proves the problem exists. A Validator Receipt proves your version of the problem is real. If no receipt exists, cap Pillar 1 confidence at 75 and say so honestly in council.

DEFENSIBILITY REQUIREMENT

Validator Receipts must be defensible under unscripted cross-examination per Rule #13 (Murder Board). If you cannot answer three follow-up questions about each named validator — their specific context, what they said during your conversation that you didn't capture in the receipt, when exactly you

spoke — the receipt is invalid regardless of what is documented. Fabricated validators collapse under Kill Shot #1. The Receipt is documentation; Murder Board is verification. Both required. A team that runs Murder Board faithfully cannot bring a fabricated Receipt past the panel; a team that skips Murder Board has neither documentation nor verification — and Pillar 1 confidence drops to 50, not 75.

■ FEASIBILITY ASSESSMENT

Honest read on what ships by submission. List the top three risks and a one-sentence mitigation per risk.

■ CALIBRATION PREDICTION (NEW v3.3)

Before submission, the team writes one sentence: **"We will place in the top [N] with [X]% confidence."** Record it. Track the Brier score over time. Brier formula for binary prediction: **BS = (forecast − outcome)².** After 5–10 events, the team's Brier track record reveals calibration failures (saying 80% when you're right 60% of the time) and resolution failures (hedging at 50% on everything).

DISTINCTION FROM PILLAR 3

The Calibration Prediction is the team's probabilistic forecast of its own placement outcome, scored by Brier score over time. It is NOT a Pillar 3 human-scale statistic. Pillar 3 stats describe the user's situation, sourced to a published primary. The two confidence numbers have different units, different sourcing requirements, and live in different fields. "We're 75% confident we'll place top-3" is not the same kind of claim as "1 in 3 foster youth experience housing instability per HHS." A Calibration Prediction measures your confidence in your execution; a Pillar 3 statistic measures the undeniable reality of the problem. High confidence in your build does not substitute for a primary citation.

"*Vague verbiage slows learning cycles.*"

07 BEFORE AFTER

Before / After Lens

Two paragraphs. The named person's life before your solution exists. The named person's life after. The lens forces specificity — you cannot write a generic Before / After without exposing a generic Pillar 1.

Construction Rules

- **Use the same named person across both paragraphs.** If the Before names Maria, the After names Maria. Switching subjects breaks the inevitability.
- **Before is concrete and physical.** What time does Maria leave the house? What does she carry? Who does she call? Where does the friction live in her actual day?
- **After is concrete and physical.** What does the new morning look like? What did the 90-minute drive get replaced with? What did she gain in the hours saved?
- **Avoid jargon in both.** No "reduced friction," no "streamlined workflow," no "optimized." Plain language only.
- **End the After with a specific moment.** A phone call, a text message, an empty parking space, a single image. Specificity beats abstraction in the judge's memory.

Where It Lives in the Pitch

The Before lands at the Hook (Pitch Arc Step 1, 30 seconds). The After lands at Impact (Pitch Arc Step 5, 30 seconds). Between them sits the Demo (Step 4) — the moment when the judge realizes the After is buildable today.

> "*If your After paragraph could describe any successful product, your Before paragraph wasn't specific enough.*"

08 IMPACT

Business Impact Framework

Pillar 5 enforced as a numerical artifact. Three numbers must appear in the pitch. Sourced. Defensible under Murder Board cross-examination.

TAM — Total Addressable Market

The total dollar value of the problem you're solving. Sourced to a primary publication or government dataset. Round to two significant figures ("$4.2 billion" not "$4,247,891,000"). If your TAM can be Googled in 30 seconds and shows up on three Wikipedia pages, it's not defensible — find the primary source.

Cost Per Incident

The cost of one instance of the problem. For StepSafe: cost of one diabetic foot amputation ($30K–$60K direct + lifetime quality-adjusted-life-year loss). For SafeHaven: cost of one episode of domestic financial abuse (varies but $1K–$80K direct asset loss, plus credit damage, plus housing displacement).

Revenue Model

Who pays, how much, why now. Three sentences max. "Hospital systems pay $200/patient/month for at-home DFU monitoring. Reimbursable under CMS chronic care management codes effective 2025. We capture 1% of US diabetic population over five years."

The Single Hardest Rule

Lead with business numbers, not tech stack. The methodology's pitch formula puts numbers in the Hook (Step 1) and Impact (Step 5). Tech stack lives at Step 6 and competes for time with Ask (Step 7). If a judge can't repeat your TAM after the pitch, you led with the wrong thing.

> "*Lead with the business numbers, not the API list. Sponsors remember dollar signs.*"

09 PITCH ARC

Pitch Arc

Seven steps. Three to five minutes total. Memorized cold via Rule #5. Backup video ready via Rule #12. Murder Board tested via Rule #13.

Step	Time	Content
01 Hook	30s	Named person Before paragraph. Pillar 3 statistic. "Maria, 64, mother of two..."
02 Problem	30s	The Gap. Pillar 2 structural barrier in plain language.
03 Solution	30s	What you built. One sentence. Tech stack stays out.
04 Demo	60–90s	The "shouldn't be possible" moment. Pillar 4 inevitability.
05 Impact	30s	After paragraph. TAM. Cost per incident.
06 Team / Tech	15s	Why you. Stack named. Founder credibility.
07 Ask + Close	15s	What you want from the judges. The line that gets remembered.

Judge Frame Routing (NEW v3.3)

In finals, do not treat the panel as one mind. Treat it as a mixed stack of lenses.

Pre-Round Lens Map

Classify each likely judge into one primary lens:

- **Investor Lens** — screens for upside, milestone velocity, why this can become large fast.
- **Operator Lens** — screens for execution path, constraints, sequencing, business-model friction.
- **Domain Lens** — screens for whether the problem, customer, and failure modes are defined precisely enough to be real.
- **Generalist Lens** — screens for coherence, legibility, and whether the value can be understood immediately.

Real-Time Question Tagging

During Q&A, tag each question in real time:

- **Promotion Question** — upside, scale, expansion, growth, ambition.
- **Prevention Question** — risk, downside, defensibility, failure, compliance, leakage.
- **Problem Question** — customer, pain, urgency, proof the problem actually matters.
- **Trust Question** — team judgment, honesty, coachability, why you can execute.

The Core Rule

Never stay trapped in the frame you were handed if that frame lowers your ceiling. If a judge asks a prevention question, answer in three moves: **Acknowledge** the risk without flinching. **Answer** with the control, evidence, or design choice that contains it. **Advance** back to upside, momentum, or the next milestone.

Mixed Panel Protocol

Script one sentence of *why* for the room (novices need this before they can follow the *how*), then move quickly to *how* for the experts (they reward concrete execution detail). Falchetti's research: novices respond better to abstract *why* framing; experts respond better to concrete *how* framing.

First Fifteen Seconds

In every answer, the first fifteen seconds are composure, clarity, and command. Judges draw competence inferences before they finish scoring substance. Tsay's research: judges given only dynamic visual information (gestures, facial expressions) were better at identifying actual winners than those given full transcripts. Opening stance, walk-on, stillness, and the first answer's delivery are score-bearing variables.

The Charm vs Competence Trap

Huang et al. found judges over-reward charm relative to managerial ability, and "charm over managerial ability" is *negatively* associated with later business outcomes. The goal is not to be charming. **The goal is to project immediate control, credibility, and executional seriousness** so fast trait inferences break toward competence, not empty likability.

SPILLOVER CAVEAT (NEW v3.3)

Judge classification (Investor / Operator / Domain / Generalist) applies to UNPROMPTED baseline judge behavior. When the event organizer or sponsor explicitly prompts judges to prioritize a specific criterion before the round, expect spillover effects that contradict the baseline. Domain experts prompted to prioritize problem definition become MORE critical of problem framing.

Investors prompted to prioritize a non-business criterion tend to DISCOUNT business model in their final scoring as compensation. Entrepreneurs prompted to prioritize impact tend to BOOST impact ratings to a degree that overshoots calibrated assessment. If you know in advance that the organizer is prompting judges (visible in the rubric pre-brief or in sponsor instructions), adjust your live answer-routing accordingly.

"*The goal of Q&A is not to survive questions. The goal is to route each question back to the win condition without looking evasive.*"

10 SPONSOR RECON

Sponsor Reconnaissance Protocol

Day 0. Before code. The Product Manager walks the sponsor tables and asks three questions at every table. Outputs feed directly into the Section 06 concept card and the Section 09 Pitch Arc Demo Moment.

THE THREE QUESTIONS

7. **"What projects are you hoping to see?"** Tells you what the sponsor's track team has been imagining. Their answer is often more specific than the public track description.
8. **"Which API or feature would you most love showcased?"** Tells you the integration that scores highest with this sponsor. If you can build it natively, you should.
9. **"What's a current pain point your team is dealing with?"** Tells you the real-world problem your demo could address. The best track wins come from teams that solved a problem the sponsor was already complaining about.

THE DIRECT ASK

When a sponsor reveals a gap or a pain point that your team can fill, **propose to fill it on the spot and get verbal commitment before building.** "If we build [X] in the next 36 hours, would your team consider us for the prize?" A verbal yes is not binding, but it is signal — and it dramatically shifts your build priorities.

What Goes in the Brief

- Sponsor name and prize track
- API / tech they want showcased
- Pain point they mentioned
- Verbal commitment status (yes / no / hedge)
- Name of the person you spoke to (use it in your pitch)

11 RUBRIC RECON

Rubric Reconnaissance Protocol

Runs in parallel with the Section 10 Sponsor Walk on Day 0. Required for all events. Execution time: 20 minutes. Owner: Product Manager.

THE CORE PRINCIPLE

Every event has a published or inferable scoring rubric. That rubric is the judge's instruction manual. **Your job is to read their instructions before they read your pitch.** Section 10 tells you what the sponsor wants built. Section 11 tells you how the judges will score it. These are two different questions.

STEP 1 — PULL THE RUBRIC BEFORE THE EVENT

- **Devpost-hosted events:** Overview → Judging Criteria section. Devpost requires organizers to list criteria before the event opens.
- **Pitch competitions:** the rubric PDF is usually linked from the competition's judging page (e.g., HBS NVC publishes its rubric PDF annually).
- **Sponsor-track events:** each sponsor prize often has its own criteria, which override the general rubric for that prize. Read both.
- **If no rubric is published:** email organizers 48 hours before with "What are the judging criteria for the general prize track?" Judges respect this — you're doing their job for them.

STEP 2 — MAP EVERY CRITERION TO A PILLAR AND AN ARTIFACT

For each criterion in the rubric, answer three questions and write the answers in your Section 06 doc before the Day 0 sponsor walk:

10. Which of the Five Pillars does this criterion most directly test?
11. Which specific moment in the Pitch Arc (Steps 01–07) proves it?
12. Which demo moment or slide makes it undeniable to a skeptical judge?

THE UNIVERSAL TRANSLATION TABLE

If the Rubric Says...	It Is Testing...	Sookra Answer Lives In...
Innovation / Originality / Creativity / WOW Factor	Pillar 2: Is the structural gap real and non-obvious?	Section 09 Step 02 (The Gap) plus the named-person stat that makes it feel inevitable
Technical Complexity / Implementation / Technical Execution	Pillar 4: Is the tech the only logical answer?	Demo moment (Step 04 of Pitch Arc) — the "shouldn't be possible" moment
Real-World	Pillar 1 + Pillar 5:	Before / After lens (Section 07)

If the Rubric Says...	It Is Testing...	Sookra Answer Lives In...
Application / Impact / Feasibility	Named person plus scale	plus TAM plus cost-per-incident (Section 08)
Demo / Presentation / Communication	Golden Rules 5, 12 plus Pitch Arc	20 rehearsals plus backup video plus Section 06 doc as the slide structure
Business Model / Market Potential / TAM	Pillar 5, Phase 1 Probes 1–3	Business Impact Framework (Section 08) — lead with TAM and cost-per-incident
User Validation / Customer Insights / Proximity	Pillar 1 plus Section 10 Sponsor Recon	Named person grounded in institutional partner, expert endorsement, or cited research; Validator Receipt
Sustainability / Ethics / Community feedback	Pillar 5 Phase 2 (Flywheel Probe)	"What gets better as more people use it?" — name the flywheel. Add: who did you talk to that confirmed this need?

STEP 3 — IDENTIFY THE HIGHEST-WEIGHT OR MOST DISTINCTIVE CRITERION

Flag the criterion where the methodology's standard output is weakest relative to the rubric's emphasis:

- **Student hackathon (Devpost, equal weights):** WOW Factor / originality is the swing criterion. Methodology already wins here via Pillars 2 and 4. No adjustment needed.
- **Sponsor finance track (YC Prize, Pear VC, Capital One):** Business model and customer insights become primary. Elevate Pillar 5 Phase 1 plus user validation evidence in the pitch — not buried after the demo.
- **Pitch competition (HBS, TechCrunch, SXSW):** Team background and conviction carry weight. Add a one-sentence founding story to Step 07 (Close) of the Pitch Arc that answers: why you, why this problem, why now.
- **Social-impact / SDG track:** Community proximity and ethical sustainability are explicitly scored. Prepare one sentence naming who you spoke to before building (institutional partner, domain expert, or 3+ cited user conversations).

STEP 4 — THE RUBRIC ALIGNMENT CHECK (60 SECONDS)

After the Section 06 doc is written and before any code is committed, run this 60-second check:

"If I were a judge scoring this submission against the published rubric right now, which criterion would score lowest? Is there a specific artifact — a slide, a demo moment, a stat — that would raise that score?"

If the answer is yes, add it. If the answer is "our concept doesn't fit that criterion," that's a concept problem, not a presentation problem — take it back to /sookra-council.

"*Section 10 tells you what to build. Section 11 tells you how it will be scored. Run both.*"

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12 PRE-MORTEM

Pre-Mortem Protocol

The Sookra Council (Section 13) validates the concept logically. The Pre-Mortem validates the concept psychologically — by forcing the team to imagine the project has already failed and reason backward to why. This catches private doubts the Council's structured probing will not.

THE PROTOCOL (20–30 MINUTES, END OF DAY 0 / START OF DAY 1 BUILD PHASE)

13. **Set the premise.** Leader: "Imagine it's Sunday submission deadline and our project has completely failed. Not underperformed — failed badly. The judges gave us nothing. Take a moment to let that land."
14. **Independent silent writing (2–3 minutes).** Every team member writes every reason for the failure they can imagine. Silent. Individual. No discussion. **This step is non-negotiable** — group discussion before individual writing destroys candor.
15. **Round-robin sharing.** One reason per person per round, written to a shared document. No critique. Continue until exhausted.
16. **Consolidate and mitigate.** Cluster reasons. Assign owners to top-ranked failure modes. The output becomes mitigation tasks for the Builder and Presenter.
17. **Sunday morning revisit.** Re-read the failure list. Has anything become more likely overnight?

WHO RUNS IT

The team that will execute the build, **NOT** sponsors or mentors. Senior-stakeholder presence collapses candor. PM facilitates; everyone participates including the Presenter.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

- **Not the Sookra Council (Section 13)** — Council probes structured pillars; Pre-Mortem surfaces unstructured doubts.
- **Not the Post-Event AAR (Section 19)** — AAR is retrospective on actual events; Pre-Mortem is prospective on a hypothetical failure.
- **Not the Murder Board (Rule #13)** — Murder Board attacks the presenter; Pre-Mortem attacks the plan.

EMPIRICAL ANCHOR

Prospective hindsight produces ~30% more failure reasons generated under "the project failed" framing versus "the project might fail" framing. **Important: the original study measured quantity of reasons, not their accuracy.** Controlled

studies have shown the Pre-Mortem produces roughly twice the plan-confidence reduction of Pros-and-Cons or Cons-only generation. Validated at hackathon-length planning horizons in game-development team studies. Hackathon-specific empirical evidence does not yet exist — Sookra's adoption is itself a contribution to that under-explored domain.

"*The plan failed. Why?*"

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13 COUNCIL

The Sookra Council

Five advisors. Each guards one Pillar. Concept passes through all five before code begins. Chairman synthesizes and delivers verdict.

THE FIVE GUARDIANS

- **Pillar 1 Guardian (Real Problem)** — Is the named person real? Is the pain specific enough? Is the Validator Receipt defensible under Murder Board?
- **Pillar 2 Guardian (Structural Gap)** — Does the gap survive all four Falsification Battery tests? Which of the six structural-barrier categories applies? Is the barrier specific enough to defend?
- **Pillar 3 Guardian (Human Stat)** — Does the stat land? Is it sourced to a primary publication? Does it make someone feel something?
- **Pillar 4 Guardian (Tech Inevitable)** — Is the tech the only logical answer or just the coolest one? Is there a "shouldn't be possible" demo moment?
- **Pillar 5 Guardian (Business Numbers)** — Two-phase probe: Foundational (TAM / cost-per-incident / revenue model) plus Flywheel Probe plus Offer-Leak Probe.

PHASE 2 PROBES (RENAMED v3.3)

The Flywheel Probe

"What gets better as more people use this?" Name the compounding mechanism. If nothing compounds, the business is a service, not a platform. The Probe catches concepts that scale linearly with effort but never accumulate moat.

The Offer-Leak Probe

"Where does the funnel leak?" Trace the path from first-touch to revenue. Name the single biggest leak. If you can't, you don't understand your own funnel. The Probe catches concepts with strong product-market fit but broken conversion.

THE CHAIRMAN'S VERDICT

After all five Guardians render their judgments, the Chairman delivers the verdict in this format:

- **Verdict:** GO / NO-GO / REFRAME
- **Weakest Pillar:** named explicitly
- **Confidence:** 0–100
- **Flip Condition:** what would move the verdict from current state to higher confidence

- **One Thing to Do First:** the single highest-leverage action before next step
- **Convergence Type (NEW v3.3):** Unanimous-Conventional / Unanimous-Unique / Split-Conventional / Split-Unique

THE CONVERGENCE TYPE FIELD

Gius's research across 67 venture competitions found that **more judge disagreement predicts startup success on truly unique propositions.** A unanimous Council GO is not necessarily stronger than a split GO/REFRAME on a unique concept. The methodology's instinct toward consensus may be filtering out the biggest potential wins.

Convergence Type	Read	Action
Unanimous-Conventional	Standard concept, all Guardians agree.	Ship if Pillars hold. Expected.
Unanimous-Unique	Novel concept, all Guardians love it.	Suspicious — the methodology's bias may be filtering criticism. Re-attack the weakest Pillar before ship.
Split-Conventional	Standard concept, productive disagreement.	Address the dissent specifically. Convert split to consensus through revision.
Split-Unique	Novel concept, productive disagreement.	Highest expected-value zone. The dissent is informative. Investigate it before flattening to consensus.

"The instinct to flatten disagreement into consensus is the methodology's blind spot. v3.3 starts collecting the data needed to fix it."

14 RESEARCH WORKFLOW

Multi-Model Research Workflow

Four rounds. Used for methodology version upgrades, deep-research synthesis, and concept-lock on complex concepts where single-model output is insufficient.

ROUND 1 — RAW GENERATION

Same prompt to multiple frontier models cold: ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Grok, Kimi, DeepSeek. Each model generates concepts or gap analyses independently. Archive every output. This produces the convergence map — gaps surfaced by multiple models are higher-confidence than singletons.

ROUND 2 — METHODOLOGY INJECTION

Re-prompt each model with the Sookra Methodology as context. Models re-refine their Round 1 output through the Five Pillars filter. This catches the concepts that survive sookra-grade scrutiny.

ROUND 3 — DEEP RESEARCH

Assign each model a specific deep-research topic based on Round 2 convergence. Each model produces a sourced report with primary citations. This is where the empirical anchors get gathered.

ROUND 4 — SYNTHESIS

Bring all outputs to Claude. Claude synthesizes across models. Run /sookra-council on the synthesis. THEN run NotebookLM for final source-grounded validation. Apply Council and NotebookLM corrections. Ship.

The Critical Ordering for Methodology Updates

For concept-lock work, the original ordering is: Synthesis → Council → NotebookLM. For methodology version upgrades, the ordering inverts: **Synthesis → NotebookLM → Council → Apply Corrections → Ship.** NotebookLM is more neutral than the Council when the object being evaluated is the methodology itself — Council uses the methodology's own logic to evaluate the methodology, which is circular.

15 TOOL RANKING

Tool Ranking

Research-stack discipline. Use each tool for what it's best at. Use them in this order.

Rank	Tool	Role
#1 — Final Validation	NotebookLM	Source-grounded. Fires LAST after concept-lock. Must be fed sources manually. Catches the things models hallucinate.
#2 — Live Web Research	Perplexity	Real-time, web-grounded. Use for stat-sourcing, judge research, sponsor research, rubric research.
#3 — Synthesis	Claude	Synthesis lane. Pulls multiple model outputs together. Runs /sookra-council. Drafts and revises methodology text.
#4 — Concept Generation	ChatGPT / Gemini / Grok / Kimi / DeepSeek	Used in parallel for Round 1 and Round 3 of the Multi-Model Research Workflow. Never trust single-model output.
Production	Napkin AI	Text-to-diagram. Pitch deck production. Slots into Round 4 after concept lock. Not a thinking tool.

The cardinal rule: NotebookLM is the final boss. Don't run it first. Lock the concept, gather the sources, then feed everything in. It validates what the Council approves — and occasionally catches what the Council missed.

16 WINS

Case Studies — Wins

Documented placements. Each case study includes the named person, the structural gap, the demo moment, and the Pillar 2 retroactive validation under v3.3's Four-Test Falsification Battery.

TRACE — 1st Place, Actian VectorAI DB Build Challenge

Forensic semantic search bridging the vocabulary gap between families and coroners for missing persons and unidentified remains. Fully on-device. Teammate: Vinh Le. Pillar 2 verdict: **PASSES all four tests** — statutory + schema barriers between NAMUS and NCIC (forensic vs layperson vocabulary, federal data-sharing restrictions).

STEPSAFE — 1st Place, HMI Hackathon

AI diabetic foot ulcer detection web app using TensorFlow MobileNetV2 (99.13% accuracy). Pillar 2 verdict: **PASSES all four tests** — liability + clinical-validation structural barrier (medical-device incumbents sell to providers, not consumers; FDA-cleared consumer DFU detection has no profitable buyer at patient price points).

SAFEHAVEN — 2nd of 4,700+ Students, Wells Fargo x GCA

AI-powered domestic financial abuse detection for Wells Fargo. Pillar 2 verdict: **PASSES all four tests** — sharpened perverse-incentive structure (banks profit from joint accounts; no entrant can profitably build at consumer scale without B2G or insurance subsidy).

PYROLENS — 2nd + 3rd Place, KSU Social Good Hackathon

AI prescribed-burn optimization platform using NOAA, NASA FIRMS, Sentinel satellite data. Pillar 2 verdict: **PASSES all four tests** — information asymmetry plus schema incompatibility (NOAA gridded weather products, state forestry parcel-GIS, and NASA FIRMS satellite raster data have no cross-agency API integration mandate at the operational decision-making layer).

SABER — 3rd Place, Vibra ATL 2026

AI diagnostic separating language barriers from knowledge gaps for Hispanic ELL students. Pillar 2 verdict: **BORDERLINE — passes 3 of 4 tests.** Test 3 is contingent on whether the team can name the structural barrier beyond market unattractiveness. If the barrier is genuinely "EdTech vendors don't prioritize ELL students," the gap reclassifies as an underfunded segment — not failure, but

honestly softer than Trace's or StepSafe's gaps. **The borderline tag is intellectual honesty, not retroactive demotion.**

ECHOPAY — 3rd Place, KSU FinTech Hackathon

Voice-native stablecoin payment platform for unbanked users with deepfake detection. Pillar 2 verdict: **PASSES all four tests** — regulatory plus onboarding barriers for unbanked (KYC walls prevent traditional fintech, voice-native interface required for accessibility).

NEST — KSU C-Day Spring 2026, In Progress

AI-powered transition navigator for aging-out foster youth in Georgia. Pillar 2 verdict: **PASSES all four tests** — statutory plus coordination-without-authority (foster youth privacy law across state-county-school systems; no entity has authority to consolidate cross-agency data).

> "*The methodology's track record is not a marketing artifact. It is the evidence base the methodology rests on. v3.3's Pillar 2 falsification battery was sharpened until the case studies it validates retroactively match the gaps the methodology claims to catch.*"

17 LESSONS

Case Studies — Lessons

Documented losses. Each case study includes the failure mode and the Pillar 2 retroactive verdict that would have caught it under v3.3.

HEXBEAR — UGAHacks 11 (Did Not Place)

Climate awareness app with gamified action steps. Pillar 2 verdict: **FAILS Test 1 (Counterfactual) plus Test 2 (Job-Lock).** Environmental nonprofits know about climate awareness and have already solved it — the space is saturated with existing apps that work well enough for the job users are hiring them to do. The barrier was saturation, not structural. **The methodology's v3.3 Pillar 2 battery would have caught this on Day 0.**

COMPASS — VibeATL 2026, Ranked 12/22

AI guide for immigrants and first-gen Americans navigating US government processes. Pillar 2 verdict: **FAILS Test 1 plus Test 3.** State DMV offices and immigrant advocacy orgs know the problem; they haven't built centralized guidance, but the barrier is coordination plus funding, not structural. With $1M, content curation plus an LLM frontend solves it. **Compass's actual loss reason — "Pillar 5 was weak, no clear revenue model or TAM" — maps exactly to the Pillar 2 failure.** Funding gaps masquerading as structural gaps produce confused business cases because there's no defensible "why us."

NEOGUIDE — Hacklytics 2026 (Did Not Place)

Smart sensor-guided neonatal intubation system with Gemini Vision API and ElevenLabs TTS. The concept itself was strong (likely passes Pillar 2 under v3.3), but the demo did not crystallize in time. **Loss reason: Pillar 4 demo execution, not Pillar 2 structural gap.** Stephen has considered reviving with hardware (Raspberry Pi 5 plus Camera Module 3 plus Coral USB Accelerator) — the structural gap remains real.

JPMC DATA FOR GOOD HBCU EDITION — Plano TX, April 2026 (Did Not Place)

EDA on 6 HUD datasets for Fort Worth Community Land Trust; weighted 8-metric scoring model; tax foreclosure prediction concept. **Loss reason: demo didn't crystallize in time** — the analytical work was strong but the presentation under pressure did not land. This is the methodology's tombstone for Golden Rule #13 (Murder Board) — a structured adversarial rehearsal would have exposed the delivery gap before judging.

"Losses are not failures of effort. They are signals about which Pillar collapsed. v3.3 was forged from these signals."

18 GOLDEN RULES

The Golden Rules

Thirteen rules. Each rule encodes a hard-won lesson from a specific loss or a specific win. Rules are not suggestions. Breaking a rule in a win is a stronger double-loop signal than following all rules in a loss.

01 Lock person and problem before tech.

Pillar 1 first. Pillar 4 last. If you start with the API and look for a problem to solve, you have already lost.

02 Lead with business numbers, not tech stack.

TAM and cost-per-incident in the Hook and Impact slots. Tech stack at Step 06. Judges remember dollar signs.

03 One named person carries the entire pitch.

Same person in Before and After. Same person in Demo and Impact. Switching subjects breaks inevitability.

04 Pillar 3 stats come from primary sources.

Peer-reviewed papers, government reports, journalism with primary citation. Never Wikipedia. Never "according to." Defensible under Murder Board.

05 Rehearse twenty times. Five for early-slot opening. (v3.3 update)

Twenty solo rehearsals before the live pitch. At least five of those optimized for the early-slot opening — pitching first or second reduces average judge interest by 0.36 standard deviations (Clingingsmith, Conley & Shane). When you draw an early slot, the first 20 seconds must over-anchor, not warm up.

06 Sponsor walks are not optional.

Section 10 protocol runs at every event. Three questions per table. Direct ask when you find a gap. Verbal commitment before building.

07 The demo is the pitch.

Steps 01–03 set up Step 04. Step 04 makes Steps 05–07 mean something. A pitch without a working demo is a pitch about a hypothetical.

08 Backup video before live demo, every time.

Rule #12 territory. Live demo failure with no backup is the single most common cause of a strong pitch losing.

09 Person plus problem before tech, every iteration.

If a mid-build pivot happens, re-validate Pillar 1 and Pillar 2 before re-validating Pillar 4. Tech-led pivots are the methodology's most common failure mode.

10 Don't trust a single model.

Multi-Model Research Workflow exists for a reason. One model's confident output is one model's confident hallucination.

11 Multi-track stacking without demo supremacy is suicide.

Pursuing multiple sponsor tracks fragments build effort. The demo moment must be supreme — every feature serves it or gets cut.

12 Backup video, recorded by Saturday evening at the latest.

Sunday morning is too late. Pre-record the demo as a 60-90 second video by Saturday night. If live demo fails during pitch, cut to video without hesitation.

13 Run a Murder Board before you pitch. (NEW v3.3)

The Council validates the concept. The Murder Board validates the presenter. Sunday morning, after the 20 solo rehearsals (Rule #5) and after the backup video is recorded (Rule #12). Three Kill Shots: weakest pillar, demo contingency, differentiation. Cap at two cycles. No defending, only "thank you, the answer is..." Murder Board is hostile cross-examination — composure under surprise, weakest-pillar defense, backup-video execution. You need both Rule #5 and Rule #13.

"*Rules are not suggestions. They are the codified outputs of specific losses.*"

19 AAR

Post-Event AAR Protocol

READ THIS FIRST

Empirical data shows only 7% of hackathon projects survive 6 months past closing ceremony (MLH GitHub analysis of 11,889 repositories). Without a formalized debrief, judge feedback decays, systemic errors cascade into the next event, and the concept dies in a GitHub repo. Two meta-analyses prove structured debriefs lift team performance 20-25% with effect sizes of d=0.67 (Tannenbaum & Cerasoli 2013, n=2,136) to d=0.79 (Keiser & Arthur 2021, n=915 teams) — statistically large effects. Section 19 is the mechanism for capturing that lift.

Run within **48 hours of event conclusion**, regardless of placement. Use only objective media (commit logs, deployment timestamps, verbatim judge quotes). The hackathon AAR absorbs the four-question military debrief structure (speed), blameless engineering culture (team cohesion), and outcome-focused longitudinal evaluation (business viability). **Frames go in. Blame goes away. The methodology stays clean.**

THE FOUR PROBES

01 — The Baseline Probe

Open the Day 0 Section 06 doc. Read the intended Problem Statement, Tech Stack, and Demo Moment aloud. Anchor the team in objective reality. Prevent hindsight bias. **You cannot evaluate a deviation if you do not admit what the baseline was.**

02 — The Ground-Truth Probe

What did the judges and the system actually see? No narratives. Objective media only: commit logs, deployment timestamps, Section 10 sponsor walk quotes, verbatim final judge Q&A. Did the live demo execute? Did Rule #12 backup video run?

03 — The Divergence Probe

Why did reality deviate from baseline? **Assume good intentions from every Builder and Presenter.** If the API failed at 3 AM, do not attack the developer. Ask the systemic question: why did our architecture lack mock data to allow frontend testing while backend struggled? Apply the outside-view check: did we fail uniquely,

or did multi-track stacking without demo-supremacy (Rule #11) fail in this predictable way?

04 — The Calibration Pivot

What is the systemic fix, and does this project survive? **Update mental models.** If TAM numbers failed to impress judges (Pillar 5), adjust the research engine. If the Murder Board did not surface the question that killed the pitch (Rule #13), tighten the Kill Shots. Evaluate the project's future — does it have structural momentum to enter the 7% that survive?

POST-AAR TRIGGER

If the Calibration Pivot concludes the concept proved its inevitability (Pillar 4) AND secured at least one verbal partner or sponsor commitment during the event, this is the trigger to activate the Board of Titans (quarantined pipeline per v3.2.1) for non-hackathon-scale work. **This is methodology-internal architecture, not an empirically-derived step of the AAR protocol itself.**

FACILITATION

PM documents. Presenter facilitates. 30–45 minutes. Self-led (research shows self-led outperforms externally-facilitated when team-aligned and objective-media-grounded).

"*Winning the room requires a demo. Winning the market requires a debrief. Don't let the artifact die on Sunday.*"

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20 RESERVED

Reserved for v3.4: Double-Loop Methodology Audit

Section 20 is reserved for v3.4 pending empirical data from Section 19 (AAR Protocol). Shipping a meta-process before the underlying process has empirical history violates the methodology's own evidence discipline.

The AAR Protocol must run on at least three events before the meta-layer that audits the methodology architecture can be designed responsibly. The conceptual frame for Section 20 — distinguishing rule-level adjustments (single-loop) from governing-variable revisions (double-loop) — holds and informs v3.4 design. **The protocol itself does not ship in v3.3.**

Section 20 returns in v3.4 grounded in Sookra's own AAR data rather than borrowed convention. This deferral is itself a methodology principle: the methodology will not ship meta-protocols on top of un-validated protocols.

"47 years of literature on Double-Loop Learning has not produced an agreed-upon empirical effect size. v3.3 chose to learn from that. v3.4 will ship the protocol with real Sookra evidence behind it."

21 CHANGELOG

Changelog · v3.2.1 → v3.3

NEW SECTIONS

- **Section 02 — Competition Fit Filter.** Six-check Sookra Fit Score (0–18). Decides whether the room is worth entering before concept work begins.
- **Section 05 — 72-Hour Pre-Game Positioning Protocol.** T-72 / T-48 / T-24 countdown. Devpost archaeology, judge mapping, repo scaffolding, dry-run, intel brief.
- **Section 11 — Rubric Reconnaissance Protocol.** Universal Translation Table mapping any rubric criterion to a Pillar plus a Section 9 artifact. Runs parallel to Section 10 Sponsor Recon on Day 0.
- **Section 12 — Pre-Mortem Protocol.** 20–30 minute structured exercise at the start of the build phase. Surfaces private doubts the Council's structured probing won't catch.
- **Section 19 — Post-Event AAR Protocol.** Four-probe debrief within 48 hours of every event. Captures the 20–25% performance lift documented by two meta-analyses.

EXPANDED SECTIONS

- **Pillar 2 — Four-Test Falsification Battery.** Counterfactual + Job-Lock + Relative Incentive + Systematic Repeatability. Plus the six-category structural-barrier taxonomy (statutory / schema / liability / training-data / perverse-incentive [sharpened] / coordination-without-authority).
- **Section 09 — Judge Frame Routing.** Pre-round lens map (Investor / Operator / Domain / Generalist) plus real-time question tagging (Promotion / Prevention / Problem / Trust) plus the Spillover Caveat for events with explicit judge prompting.
- **Section 06 — Validator Receipt plus Calibration Prediction.** Two new required Section 9 fields. Validator Receipt has a defensibility clause coupled to Rule #13. Calibration Prediction has a strict boundary distinguishing it from Pillar 3 statistics.

UPDATED SECTIONS

- **Rule #5 — Pitch-order rehearsal addendum.** At least five of the twenty rehearsals optimized for early-slot opening (Clingingsmith, Conley & Shane: 0.36 SD pitch-order effect).
- **Section 13 (The Council) — Convergence Type field.** Chairman's Verdict now records Unanimous-Conventional / Unanimous-Unique / Split-Conventional / Split-Unique.

- **Section 13 (The Council) — Phase 2 probes renamed.** Bezos-frame → Flywheel Probe. Hormozi-frame → Offer-Leak Probe. The methodology absorbs frames, not founder names — v3.3 closes the four naming-discipline leaks.

NEW GOLDEN RULE

- **Rule #13 — Run a Murder Board Before You Pitch.** Sunday morning, after Rule #5 and Rule #12. Three Kill Shots. Cap at two cycles.

DEFERRED TO v3.4

- **Section 20 — Double-Loop Methodology Audit.** Held until Section 19 has produced AAR data from 3+ events. Conceptual frame preserved; protocol does not ship in v3.3.

CUT

- Kill Criteria as standalone Golden Rule (folded into Section 04 Builder role).
- Pre-event team recruitment as standalone protocol (folded into Section 05 chemistry call).
- Fallback evidence packet as standalone rule (covered by Rule #12).
- Adjacent competitive learning systems analogies (deferred — evidence base not strong enough).

v3.3 VALIDATION RECORD

- Phase 1 gap analysis: 6 frontier models, 6/6 convergence on AAR Protocol gap.
- Phase 2 deep research: 6 models, targeted by gap area.
- NotebookLM validation: 15 questions, 5 corrections applied (Section 16 deferral, perverse-incentive sharpening, Validator Receipt defensibility, Calibration / Pillar 3 distinction, PyroLens reframe).
- /sookra-council verdict: GO on v3.3 minus original Section 16. Confidence 87.
- Total revisions applied across the full pipeline: 14 substantive corrections from original Phase 2 synthesis to ship-ready v3.3.

"*v3.3 was forged through six frontier models, validated against published academic literature, stress-tested by five Pillar Guardians, and refined until every claim could survive hostile expert review. Convergence this clean is rare — and the methodology earned every bit of it.*"

— END —

Sookra Methodology v3.3 · Private Working Document · Stephen Sookra · May 2026